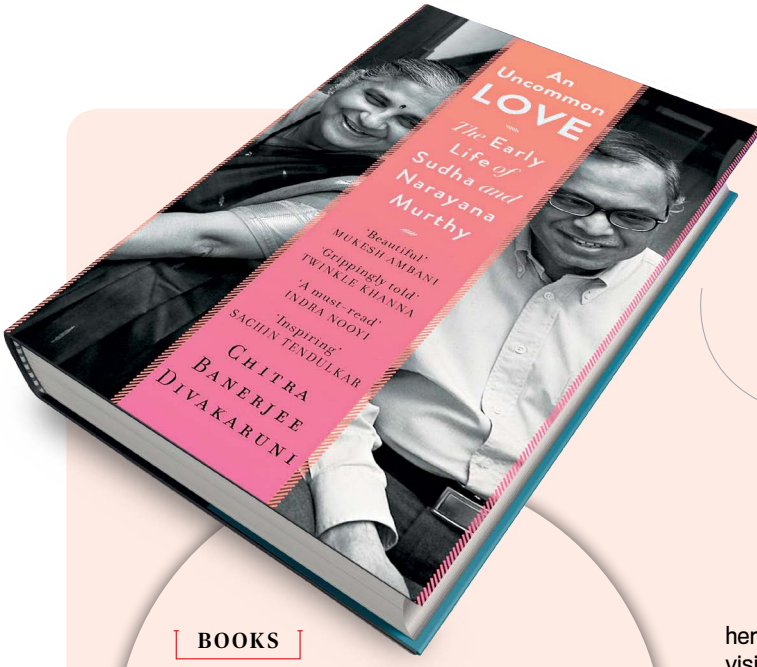



**AN UNCOMMON LOVE: The Early Life of Sudha and Narayana Murthy**
*by Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni*
JUGGERNAUT
**₹699; 352** pages

BOOKS

# Infosys: A Love Story

AN INSPIRING BIOGRAPHY THAT CHARTS THE EARLY YEARS OF THE MURTHYS' RELATIONSHIP—AND OF INFOSYS

**Anyone who's worked with the Indian tech industry** likely has personal stories about the Murthys, as I do. From meeting the man in Infosys's tiny office in Bangalore's Koramangala in the 1990s to being given a guided tour of their spanking new Bangalore campus by Narayana Murthy, to his taking notes when I spoke at a media workshop on what editors look for in news. A common thread: he was a listener, never missed details, and was polite and humble to a fault. The humility of the First Couple of Indian Tech may be a social media meme now—but there's truth there.

Indo-American fiction author Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni's book, *An Uncommon Love*, tells the early life stories of Sudha and Narayana Murthy, of the opposition their marriage faced, and the making of a storied global tech firm. Divakaruni explains how hesitant she was about writing this. But Murthy had read one of her books, and was keen to have her write their story.

Sudha Kulkarni was TELCO's first female engineer. On a day in 1974, her colleague and fellow book-lover Prasanna urged her to come home to meet his flatmate. That friend had more books than she had even heard of, and an intrigued Sudha overcame her hesitation about visiting a male colleague's home. "You lit up the room when you walked into our flat," that flatmate, Murthy, would tell her later.

Murthy asked her out to dinner the next day. Sudha picked Poona Coffee House, made it clear that she would pay for herself, and insisted that Prasanna accompany them.

For industry veterans and start-up founders alike, the snapshots of the early days of Infosys are fascinating. An anti-business government, with bureaucrats who looked at software entrepreneurs as "crooks out to cheat the government of taxes and sell products illegally". The impossibility of getting a phone line without 'connections'. The many trips to Delhi, sitting at a government office to plead for a licence to import a single computer...

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Long before he met Sudha, Murthy's first venture, Softronics, had failed. Murthy went job hunting and joined Patni Computer Systems, doing well for himself there till he found himself, as a senior manager, at the receiving end of a Patni family member's ire ("You're just an employee!"). That episode put Murthy off family businesses. He set up Infosys as a professional firm, with unprecedented share offerings to co-founders—some of it against money lent out by Sudha. Yet he refused to let Sudha join Infosys, startling and hurting her by his refusal. That refusal may have helped chart Sudha's course as a star in her own right. She's known today as an educator, author, philanthropist and not just as the founding chairperson of Infosys Foundation.

Few authorised biographies in India look very critically at their subjects, and neither does this book, which is at the centre of a barrage of publicity around the protagonists' early life and humble beginnings. Interestingly, the author doesn't mention the Murthys' famous son-in-law, Rishi Sunak, at all.

This book does jump back and forth in time, and a chronology would have helped. Despite minor gaps, this is an inspiring and a very readable, if unusual, biography. ■

**–Prasanto K. Roy**